

# Too Straight a Bat

Though an accurate portrait of the legend, the book has a runaway excess of hero worship

By Sharda Ugra

In contemporary cricket, old legends don't fade away: they just turn up on tv. Which means that the working life of a professional athlete gets a profitable extension but the legend just becomes that bit more accessible, the aura glows a little less luminously. Indian cricket's first modern legend, Sunil Gavaskar, is in that position today. The millions who grew up in the 1970s and '80s will always hanker for the legend. Gavaskar as pioneer, resistance figure, Horatius in white-flannels, the radical steeped in orthodoxy, the man who showed the world that Indian cricket knew no fear.

To their children, though, as blasphemous as the idea seems, Gavaskar is foremost a famous commentator and columnist. Who wears a hat and gets enraged when India plays badly or when some *Homo Anglo-Australis* gets uppity or when Munaf Patel doesn't tuck his shirt into his trousers.

*SMG: A Biography of Sunil Manohar Gavaskar* by Devendra Prabhudesai is an attempt to tell the story of both halves of Gavaskar's life in the public eye. Prabhudesai, currently manager, media relations and corporate affairs of the BCCI, worked with Gavaskar's company PMG for seven years. So along with meticulous research and numerous interviews, a large helping of hero-worship played a part in compiling this 500-page plus tome. The book is an accurate reflection of the Gavaskar we remember in the sepia scoresheets of our memories. But surely even the most staunch SMG-phile would baulk at this: "Sunil Gavaskar's impact on Indian cricket can be compared to the Mahatma's on India's struggle for independence." (Never mind what the Gandhians would say.)

It is now 22 years since his retirement at the end of a 16-year international career. SMG is still a very influential figure in Indian cricket; his opinion matters; his inputs have changed domestic cricket at a fundamental level. His name still produces a range of extreme responses which an unauthorised biography should tackle with relish. Yes, SMG takes on the West like he took on fast bowling, but his famous candour is often frustratingly selective. At their peak, major crises—like match-fixing or Greg Chappell's coup over Sourav Ganguly—were left alone.

Prabhudesai is a loyal chronicler. *SMG* has enough to bring back and illuminate some memories. A nuanced portrait of a complex man, though, it is not. That book is yet to be written. ■



**SMG: A BIOGRAPHY OF SUNIL MANOHAR GAVASKAR**  
by DEVENDRA PRABHODESAI  
Rupa  
Price: Rs 395  
Pages: 537

## TOP 10

A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

### FICTION

1. *Slumdog Millionaire*  
Vikas Swarup, Black Swan
2. *The Associate*  
John Grisham, Arrow
3. *The White Tiger*  
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins
4. *The 3 Mistakes of My Life*  
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
5. *The Rozabal Line*  
Ashwin Sanghi, Westland

### NON-FICTION

1. *Stay Hungry Stay Foolish*  
Rashmi Bansal, CIE, IIM-Ahmedabad
2. *Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight*  
Rujuta Diwekar, Random House
3. *Outliers: The Story of Success*  
Malcolm Gladwell, Allen Lane
4. *Imagining India: Ideas for the New Century*  
Nandan Nilekani, Allen Lane
5. *The Audacity of Hope: Thoughts on Reclaiming the American Dream*  
Barack Obama, Three Rivers Press/Canongate

### OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

#### FICTION

6. *Sea of Poppies*  
Amitav Ghosh, Penguin/Viking
7. *Six Suspects*  
Vikas Swarup, Doubleday
8. *A Girl Like Me*  
Swati Kaushal, Penguin

#### NON-FICTION

8. *The 24x7 Marriage: Smart Strategies for Good Beginnings*  
Vijay Nagaswami, Westland
10. *26/11: Mumbai Attacked*  
Harinder Baweja, Roli
13. *Daughters of Shame*  
Jasvinder Sanghera, Hachette

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Teksons, Land Mark, Crossword; Mumbai: Oxford, Shah Book Stall, Modern Book Shop; Bangalore: Gangarams, Land Mark; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Land Mark

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